Kevin Casas Subsequent Chapter Critique

Emily Beckler

I really enjoyed reading this second foray into your fantasy world. I think that the plot changes you've made to your first chapter (that I've gathered from the synopsis) were for the better, and I like how you have fleshed out the world of magical abilities.

I like the concept of a university for those with magical abilities where they hone their powers. One of my critiques about this submission is that I would have loved to see more detail regarding this school. I know that technically this chapter jumps ahead in your story, but for the purposes of this submission I would have liked to see more details about setting for the school: what does it look like? Is it more like a modern-day university buildings, or an Oxford-esque campus? Where is it? I was a bit thrown off by the bordering forest, it left me wanting more details about where the school was situated.

I also like how you have deepened the characterization for Lucas, I felt like I got more of his personality out of this piece and I liked the concept of him being "sparked" - a very neat way to single him out in that kind of chosen-one archetype. I also thought you did a great job with Jason's character, I loved the dynamic between them in their tutoring session and I felt that he had a nicely strong personality. I would have loved to see Caleb and the dynamic between him and Lucas, although I think I can guess why that isn't possible for the plot! One critique that I had for this submission was the section where Lucas sort of rants all of his emotions at an imaginary Calen - it felt like a kind of cheap plot device to get the reader inside of his head about what he was thinking and feeling. Maybe it worked for other people, but I felt that you could have done that throughout the chapter instead of sort of doing it in one dump this way: show don't tell!

My final critique is something that I'm sure we will discuss in class tomorrow - do you think that this feels a little bit too close to the Harry Potter series? Obviously tropes are tropes and nothing is completely original, but the idea of a school for magical persons certainly makes me think of HP - though I do think you have done a nice job of making the types of magic more distinct and separate from Harry Potter. I think that the aforementioned use of more details would help you out too, as you could make your school more distinct and different from Rowling's. For example, Sky High comes to mind as an example of a school for people with super abilities that is very much its own thing from Harry Potter. Mostly, however, it was the whole forest and werewolf bit - for me it felt a bit too close to the forbidden forest and the Remus Lupin plotline in Harry Potter. I didn't really understand why there were werewolves, it didn't seem to fit in with your worldbuilding of magically-tinged persons - are there other magical creatures out there like unicorns and dragons? Traditional magical creatures and your concept of almost superpowered persons don't really seem to fit together.

All in all, I really liked this submission! I think that you have a very interesting storyline and characters, and I'm excited to discuss where you plan on taking the story!

Kevin,

I really enjoyed seeing the expanded world in your later chapter! I like the glimpses of the magic school you introduce us to, and I think you once again did a really good job showing realistic interactions between Lucas and his peers (like with Julia and Katherine, and now Jason and Caleb). I also thought your idea of a Conduit was super interesting and unique!

I'm curious about the social dynamics at the school. Is Lucas an outcast because people think being "sparked" is unnatural? Is it because the kids of magical families have all known each other growing up, and he's a total outsider? (Maybe in that case Caleb would think he was a breath of fresh air compared to the people he'd been going to school with since childhood). I think it's worth thinking about exactly why and how Lucas feels so socially excluded at the university.

I'm also wondering why he's leaving in the middle of the school year. Does the magical university start in April for some reason? Does he need remedial summer classes to catch up? Why doesn't he need to graduate high school, and as such a high-achieving student, why doesn't he fight to (or does he)? I'm guessing you'll fill this info in in the in-between chapters, but as a reader those are definitely questions I'd want answered!

There are a few tropes in your story you're going to want to make sure you differentiate. None of these is a bad thing, as long as you're conscious of them and trying to put your own spin on them:

1. The magical school. How is it different from Hogwarts, Camp Half-Blood, Breakbills (Have you read *The Magicians* by Lev Grossman? If not, it's a must-read!).
2. The magical psychic dreams with someone mysterious calling for help. There are lots of ways you can invert that,
3. The forest at a magic school that maybe has werewolves. It feels very *Harry Potter*, especially in Book 1 where everyone's warning about werewolves. I'm assuming the forest in your novel isn't forbidden; is it a place people go?
4. The villain telling the Conduit why he's taking the Conduit's power. This one I would be wary of, since you want to get Lucas the information, but at the same time it feels cornier than the moment you have going on otherwise.

Another thing: I don't know why this stuck out to me, but it seems like the Sun Spirit/Conduit creature talking to Lucas is almost *too* forthcoming. I want him to work harder to ask this creature for the information he needs. You have the Conduit spilling answers to almost all the questions Lucas has had during these dreams over the course of weeks. Can you impede that in some way? Like, the Conduit is in pain from being bound up and can only answer Lucas's overwhelming questions in pieces? Eventually Lucas does get cut off, but I felt like we were getting answers too easily.

In this scene, I'm also not seeing much of a sense of urgency that the Conduit being is trying to get Lucas to let it out. Why not? He's been begging for help for so long. There's a villain coming. I think you can make the conversation with the Conduit feel more rushed, and it would help both build suspense and not feel like you're giving away all the answers.

Last, a small note: look out for filter words like “began to”. There’s a paragraph on page 12-13 that uses it 4 times, and I don’t think any of those times it’s really needed.

Anyways, overall great job and I’m looking forward to hearing more about the story in class!

Best,

Elizabeth

Peer Critique for Kevin Casas, from Meredith Dietz

First, thank you for sending in your work! The synopsis was helpful for orienting where this story is going. Most importantly, I felt that your writing itself has come a long way compared to the first chapter. Lucas's character seems both more sympathetic and interesting. The story itself also has ever-increasing intrigue.

Right away, I was drawn to the mystery surrounding "The Voice." However, the opening dialogue threw me off – I'm guessing that Lucas is trying to sound sarcastic, but I found it a bit distracting. It might even undermine the suspense of the situation.

Then, something that would be interesting (to me) would be the actual internal feeling of using powers. The jump from the start of the lesson to an hour into it seemed like a missed opportunity! While reading *Percy Jackson,* for example, I remember adoring the parts when Percy felt a tugging sensation in his gut as he controlled water – as a reader, I yearned to feel it too. While you probably would have explained those feelings in an earlier chapter, describing it here could serve as more room for character development! For instance, does it at first feel harder for Lucas to conjure powers around Jason? Does it come all from his head, or also his heart, or his gut? In fact, I feel like you do an amazing job of describing the ease with which Jason manipulates his powers. The mechanics of these powers could help make your writing original, as well as connecting the reader to the character's mental and physical state. It could help make it all feel more real.

This chapter does a good job of complicating Lucas's feelings toward Caleb. I thought it was clever of you to have the false confrontation scene, where Lucas vents to an apparition that he thinks is Caleb. However, I might have misunderstood the logistics of this part (to be discussed)!

The last major note I have concerns the rush of action at the end of this chapter. While it was all exciting, it felt a bit overloaded, like the end of an action movie. Each of the major events could have occupied its own chapter: figuring out the voice, understanding what conduits are, learning about the enemy, learning that the enemy is then a werewolf…there was no time for suspense, it all transpired so quickly. Moreover, I was thrown off by the classic trope of a villain over-explaining their plan. You have fascinating ideas and a clear image of them in your head – don't give them to the readers all at once! Experiment with what you can strategically withhold for a more satisfying action scene later on.

Finally, I wanted to note some questions I still have regarding worldbuilding. Does this place function like a normal school, but for superpowers? What else makes it distinct? How is it all kept secret?

I can't wait to learn more about what you have in store. Looking forward to discussing in class. Great work!

Thank you,

Meredith

Julia Piraino 3/10/19

ENGL 3378 Critique of Kevin Casas Chapter 2

Dear Kevin,

This was an exciting read! I'm concerned that we learn a little too much too fast in this chapter. Some things could be explained earlier on (like, wouldn't Lucas have learned about Entities and Conduits in his classes? Does all magic come from Entities, or just photokinetic magic?) while others might be left a mystery for a later chapter (I don't feel like the Entity would take the time to explain how sparking works if the more pressing matter is that he must be freed). I also think your bad guy gives way too much away—the "evil monologue explains everything" trope can be funny sometimes, but I would advise you to pull back on that here. I understand he thinks he'll soon have the Entity in his possession, so telling him his plan poses no risk, but again, I just don't think he'd take the time to explain himself. If it's more of a pride thing, like, "how dare you not use your magic to its full potential for good," make that clearer! Give us just enough that we get the gist of things, but leave some things obscured.

I also have some questions about the world. You mention the school trains magic users for their careers. Do they have magical careers, or do they just need to know how to control their abilities to live normal lives? Is there some greater purpose all magic-users are working towards? What are they protecting the magic from—ne'er-do-wells in general, or some more specific threat? Are werewolves a part of this magic-verse, or is that much more an urban legend? Obviously that all doesn't need to go in this chapter, but it should get explained somewhere.

Overall, this was a fun and well-paced read. I especially like the double fake-out (oh no, is Caleb the villain? Oh wait, is he the werewolf?) and the conflict Lucas feels about having learned so quickly from Jason. Best of luck!

Erin Norris ENGL 3378

Critique (2nd Chapter) For: Kevin Casas

Hello, Kevin! Overall, I think your writing is a lot stronger in this chapter – I can tell that you really took the class's constructive criticism to heart, and it seems like you have far more of a sense of where Lucas is as a character and the world around him. I really enjoyed the first half of the chapter especially – mainly, I wish you had expanded on a few things more.

One of the first things I picked up on is that I felt that your dream sequence could be a bit longer – I want immersive dreams that feel as though they could really be *real*, even if something surreal is happening. I definitely want more description – the fact that it's an empty white space isn't interesting at first, especially as novels thrive on the settings that you describe. I would recommend thinking about what aspects of a dream can be symbolic and incorporating that, even if it's some kind of prophetic vision – after all, dreams never play by the rules of reality; prophecies portrayed through said dreams don't necessarily have to, either. Secondly, I would continue to work towards cultivating a focus on showing instead of telling – there are a few times when you tell us how Lucas is feeling (i.e. saying he's 'getting riled up' on page 7 – that sounds like something I would say to describe something else, but the reader is in Lucas's head – focus on his physiological reactions. In general, I think that you could benefit from using more description overall – you have the bare bones, but there's definitely a lot that can be fleshed out by bringing the reader more into your world. Don't be afraid to over-describe to an extent – you can always cut out the bad stuff, which is way easier than trying to figure out exactly what you're missing.

I do have to say that I was a little disappointed by the direction that the chapter went towards, however. Lucas just happening to bump into the creature that governs his kind of power (presumably on a global scale) is an incredibly unlikely event, and even considering that all novels must have a high level of happenstance in order for characters' plotlines to intersect, it felt kind of hackneyed. I was also kind of taken aback by the werewolf – from our discussions in class, I had thought that the magic was going to be the brunt of the fantastical content. Unless it's something that you've implied to be commonplace among magical types in your story before, I would caution you against using too many of these fantasy elements – for me, it felt as though it was coming out of left field. Overall, though, great work – I can't wait to have the discussion in class tomorrow.

Samantha Crimmins

Kevin Casas

Critique 2

Dear Kevin,

Thanks for sharing your latest submission with us! I have critiques for both your synopsis and your submission. I've also attached your line edits in a separate document. Please do not be alarmed by the excess of edits! I wanted to give you as much feedback as I possibly could so you have options to take-or-leave different input.

For your synopses, I'm a bit confused on some plot points and concerned about certain character developments. Foremost, if Lucas has worked extremely hard all four years of high school, why did he only get into one school? He doesn't seem like the kind of person that would put the weight of his future on one decision. Additionally, Lucas needs a really good reason for not telling his family about his powers. Although they are in a tough financial situation, his family seems like the kind of people that would be otherwise very supportive of his future. This same things can be said for his best friends. If he is in a school where he feels like an outcast, there should be a deep level of trust in your long-term high school best friends.

On the topic of Lucas's friends, I think your reader is going to require much more insight into how he manages to leave his entire support system. You've created such great connections through your dialogue in the first

chapter submission that it’s disconcerting that Lucas would abandon everyone to pursue his own thing. A potential remedy for this is to have Lucas have focused too much on school that he doesn’t have other friends. Katherine and Julia can be schoolmates that he ends up meeting at the magic school instead, either as friends of Caleb or some of his first friends. This is a consideration that I want to emphasize because I struggled to understand why Lucas would be so unpopular at the new school. If being ‘sparked’ is something of a legend then I would suspect students would be eager to meet him and learn his secret. Also, making Lucas more likable will allow more dialogue between him and other students. That way we, as readers, get more insight into your characters.

Lastly, for the synopsis at least, I have a suggestion regarding the recruiter and Lucas’s outburst. I think the school scene is a fabulous outbreak, but I’m not sure how the recruiter would know about it if it was so rare. Instead, if you’re already going to put the effort into creating a scene where Lucas is researching special abilities, then he should find *something* to keep it from being a waste. Maybe he finds a phone number on a janky looking website or in an old newspaper clipping from an online archive.

As for the chapter itself, there were a few writing errors that I want to touch on that were frequent in your submission, many of which you will notice in the line edits that I provided. First, many terms need to be adjusted to reflect the past tense. The inconsistency of this is a bit disorienting, but is an easy correction. Second, I noticed that you have a tendency to switch

between the third person narrative, first person narrative, and internal dialogue too often. The best example that I could find of this is in the following sentence: "*Maybe I should go get help?* It might be easier to find The Voice with more people looking…someone was begging for his help and I can't just do nothing in response." Unless you're emulating Kurt Vonnegut, this is extremely jarring to read. On a similar note, I suggest that you remove all questions that appear in the narrative or internal dialogue. They distract from the action. Even the thought "*Maybe I should call him or send him a message to see if he's alright?"* can be transformed into an action sequence by replacing it with some variation of the following:

Lucas pulled out his phone and drafted a text to Caleb.

Hey, are we still meeting today?

He stared at the text message until the backlight on his phone dimmed. Lucas erased it and typed a new message.

Hey, how's it going? Want to practice today?

Stupid, he thought to himself.

"Hey, Lucas. What's up?"

Furthermore, in scenes that feature two male characters, make sure you are frequently identifying the characters to which you are referring instead of using the ambiguous "he." For example, you write, "Maybe Caleb was using his powers, on him. He could have been using his empathic abilities to mess with his emotions, making him feel closer to him than they really were." This may be better understood if you used their names more

like, “Lucas questioned Caleb. He wondered whether Caleb was manipulating his emotions with the empathic ability so that Lucas would feel like they were closer than they really were.” Lastly, replace all instances of “it began” with “it” and “could feel” with the actual feeling. For example, “it began to squirm in its restraints” can simply be re-written as “it squirmed against its restraints” and “he felt his power fade” can be written “his power faded.”

Some scenes have fabulous ideas, but I want more detail. For example, in place of “Its body was slightly translucent, and he could see that there was a strange energy that flowed through its form, as if it was a construct of pure light”, this line can be written “The anaconda-like body was slightly translucent and a [descriptor] flowed through the horrific beast like it was the embodiment of pure light energy.” Instead of “he was amazed” or “the strange [anything]”, describe a visceral reaction or tangible reason for the obscurity.

Purely from a plot perspective, there were a few scenes that could use more execution. First, the interaction between Lucas and the entity is way too casual. Second, you might be revealing too much about the strange man’s motives in this chapter. Third, there’s simply too much happening in this chapter. Between the dream, training, apparition of Caleb, the journey into the woods, the appearance of the entity, and the thief; the chapter does not have a clear focus. Please see comments within the line-edits for further questions and considerations to the plotline.

Best,

Sam

Kevin,

I really enjoyed this chapter of *Sparked*! First off, I liked the changes you made to the plot in your synopsis — I think it makes a lot more sense to have him be in a financial situation where he needs a scholarship to go to his dream school, and the reality of the situation makes that dream out of reach for him. It ups the stakes a lot more than having him be stressed about being valedictorian, and it seems like a reasonable trigger for his powers to emerge for the first time.

In terms of this chapter, I thought there was a lot of really good stuff here. I thought it was paced well, between the conversation with Jason and the discovery of the physical manifestation of The Voice. I don't think that this necessarily needs to be split into two chapters, but if you do decide to go that route, you have a pretty natural split between the Lucas/Jason scenes and the other scenes that are more focused on the mystery. I really liked the introduction of the internal conflict in the first half, where Lucas begins to doubt whether Caleb is a good tutor for him or not. This is a really interesting dynamic to play with, especially if you're planning on introducing some sort of romantic relationship between the two. I also got a sense that Caleb knows more about Lucas than he's letting on (I'm not sure if that's true, but I definitely felt that vibe), and that was why he ended up skipping the tutoring session. If so, I think that's fun and I can't wait to hear about your plans for Caleb's character.

In terms of areas to improve, I think my biggest note would be dialogue. Some of Lucas's dialogue winds up reading a bit stilted at times, so maybe go through his lines and read them out loud, and imagine if that's how an 18-year-old boy would say those things. Also, with the mysterious antagonist introduced at the end, I thought his dialogue fell into a little bit of a

cartoonish villain stereotype (specifically, when he says, “How dare you get in the way of my plans! I’m going to make your last moments utter torture!”). Another very tiny note is to decide whether you want The Voice to be capitalized or not and make sure to be consistent throughout.

All in all, great work! Looking forward to our discussion in class tomorrow.

Julia

Emily Gaudet’s Review of Kevin’s Chapter

Hi Kevin,

Very interesting following chapter so far! What I love about your writing is that, although a lot of this material could be confusing to readers, you break it down so concisely, allowing us to understand what is going on throughout the entire chapter— which is great!

Along with how concise you are throughout, it seems that this chapter is clearly leading us into the climax of the story. This chapter is almost read as introductory, introducing us to Lucas’ struggles, while still maintaining the mystery of the restrained creature. The main suggestion I would make regarding this chapter is that I wish Lucas’ story was clearer to the reader. While I know you are going to have chapters in between your first and this one, it may be beneficial for Lucas to make mention of why he misses home so dearly, how incredibly he misses Katherine and Julia. They were such vital characters in the beginning of the story that I wish their presence was somewhat apart of Lucas’ journey.

Additionally, Lucas is hearing this voice both in and out of his dream, yet is not as scared of it as I would expect. You go into detail about his fear to enter the woods, yet these voices don’t seem to scare him at all. Especially for someone who is still trying to mask their powers, constantly hearing voices would definitely be fearful to anyone. Lastly, how is Lucas able to see these apparitions? Why did it come in the form of Caleb? While I understand that it was probably the restrained creature trying to get his attention, why

was it in the form of Caleb? Maybe in the form of Katherine or Julia would be more enticing to follow it’s instructions. That is that last bit that I was a little confused about while reading. Overall, your story is so intriguing, especially for a magic-lover like myself. Good job!

Sydney Couval
Critique 2 for Kevin Casas
3/10/19

This chapter had some really great aspects to it! I really loved Lucas's character development. His questioning of his relationship with Caleb shows a lot of potential for growth, and could show him coming out of his geeky, socially unaware shell to demand more from his relationships. Lucas's voice can sometimes come across as too earnest and innocent, but you could work that into his character in a brilliant way. As he becomes more confident in himself and his relationships you could be mindful of his dialogue, and make him sound less eager to please and more in control. The reader gets to see a bit of this when he is talking to the illusion, and I hope you carry this over as he develops. However, I did not like how Lucas made the illusion to talk to him. It seemed awkward that he is ranting out loud at someone who isn't there in such a diligent way. The illusion read like imaginary friend and makes Lucas seem immature. I would suggest having him make the illusion simply because he is thinking about Lucas and wants to test his powers, then have him sit down and start thinking again, maybe throw a rock at the illusion and mutter a line of the monologue, and then have him get extremely frustrated and worked up (as is consistent with his character from his explosion in the first chapter) then have him rant at the thing. This flow of events comes across as less contrived and more realistic.

That being said, I also loved the foil of Caleb with Jacob. Lucas's questioning of the teaching method also shows him expanding his mindset, and though I didn't like the setup of the monologue, I thought it had important character development in it. I suggested the alternate version of events because the illusion leads to another one of my favorite parts: the illusion coming alive and becoming the dream voice. This actually spooked me! In a really good way! It was a great example of suspense writing. My critique of this part is the same as the first few pages: Lucas's reactions seem very underplayed and unrealistic. In the beginning his dream reaction to the voice seems like a parody of the people in horror movies who completely ignore common sense. He is way too casual. Same with meeting the serpent. You did a great job of describing Lucas's physical reactions in the first chapter, but his breath doesn't even quicken when he sees this new creature. "Dumbfounded" does not seem like the right descriptor here, more like terrified. Because he has no reaction, the ensuing conversation seems awkward and forced.

Other than the few awkward moments the pacing was good. I do think it should be broken up into two chapters, with the first ending when Lucas decides to go into the forest. This makes the first chapter more inner quest focused and the second outer quest.

Oh my god, Caleb is the werewolf. I loved the foreshadowing and I loved the ah-ha moment I had when reading! You are an excellent storyteller. Overall this is a great chapter for Lucas's development, and was very entertaining.

Kevin,

First, I would like to commend you on your writing style and the voice you embedded throughout your two chapters, as it is very fitting for the Young Adult genre/scene. Your writing is clear in terms of comprehension, creative, and exciting. Well done!

In addition, I really enjoyed the humorous, kid-like lines/word choice throughout such as "snore-fest." This makes your story really appealing to the young adult audience and it makes your novel simply fun to read. I also loved how Lucas was struck because he was in a state of vulnerability. This sets your storyline apart from Harry Potter, and distinguishes it quite a bit because it takes away from the whole "I was born with it, I am the chosen one" narrative. Great job making your story different from a piece of work that is a bit similar and known to all people.

In terms of critiques, I would recommend showing versus telling in various parts throughout your chapter. I felt as though Lucas' and Caleb's relationship could have been drawn out and expressed to the reader through a small (even cute) anecdote in the beginning of your chapter instead of merely explaining the bond they've created.

Additionally, I felt as if the writing structure became repetitive with "Lucas did this" "Lucas did that." My suggestion would be to just go back and take away some sentences that start with "Lucas...." and simply restructuring the information into action, therefore the reader is more so watching the story unfold as they read versus being told it. (If that makes sense).

Overall, great job! You have an amazing piece.

Sincerely,

Juliana

Nathan Worob’s Review of Kevin’s Subsequent Chapter

Oh man, now I really feel like I’m getting the gist of the story. The progression into Lucas’s magical capabilities is starting to feel more self-contained and directional, a desire put into effect by the wanting had in the first chapter. He feels more in charge of his agency, which as a character is so important.

My biggest recommendation so far is going to again be about dialogue choices. It feels sort of campy so far in a way akin to many teen dramedy shows, and I really think it has potential to be multi or transcendent of that genre set. Specifically, I think less general banter between the characters is actually a really great idea. Make them talk some without having them needing to joke around, and incite them along those lines to develop communications (and relationships?) in a more relatable-to way.

Additionally, I think the world building here is excellent. Maybe this is a chapter where that can play an even bigger role, with other magic users and related folks being referred to. That sort of inclusion will help both envision the hero’s journey (less than literally) and the world around them. Descriptors for these characters would be quite helpful then.

All in all, great improvement over time! I look forward to seeing how this progresses.